BEWARE OF SWINDLERS

HOW TO PROTECT YOURSELF FROM ONLINE FRAUDS

DOs

- Always visit the official website of bank/merchant for correct customer care number
- Keep your contact details updated with the bank to get transaction alerts
- Secure your debit/credit cards and set daily limit for transactions
- Use strong passwords; should be different for banking & e-commerce
- Report any unauthorised transaction to your bank to prevent further losses

DON'Ts

- Enter UPI PIN or scan QR code to receive payments; you'll end up losing money
- Save your banking username/ password in the web browser or your device
- Click any link shared in SMSes/ mails typically threatening to block your bank account
- Download third-party apps on assurance that it will help resolve your complaints
- Share your ID/ login password, OTP, CVV, etc. with anyone claiming to be a bank representative

WHAT TO DO IN CASE YOU HAVE BEEN DUPED

- Call bank customer care and ask them to freeze account, credit/debit cards, net banking mandate, within the first 48 hours of the fraud occurring
- Call 1930, the cyber helpline. Alternatively, file a complaint on *cybercrime.gov.in*, or visit your nearest cybercrime police branch
- Change PINs and passwords to all online accounts
- Run phone diagnostics to delete suspect apps or malware

providers in the same name. Being thus in possession of the subscriber's record, the retailer could use it for subsequent verification to activate other SIM cards.

In June, a team led by Pinak Mishra, the deputy commissioner of police, Cuttack, busted one such racket. They recovered 799 fake SIM cards from one Gyan Ranjan Patra, a law student in Odisha, and his accomplices. The accused would sell these to cyber criminals operating in Assam, Delhi and Rajasthan for Rs 1,000 per card. When the cyber experts examined Patra's cellphone, they found that the IMEI or the International Mobile Equipment Identity number (a unique identity for every cellphone in the world) on his phone had 5,000 entries, which means he used his phone to activate as many SIM cards in three months. Since these cards are activated in third-party names, tracing them is next to impossible.

Armed with fraudulently acquired SIM cards, cyber crooks move on to bait their quarry. This is done either by casting a wide net in the hope that someone gets caught, or by approaching the target directly—via a call or a message on social networking platforms like Facebook, Telegram or WhatsApp, or popular e-commerce platforms. Technology meets native ingenuity to defraud people in multiple ways and at multiple levels (see *The Many Ways You Can Be Duped of Your Money*). In the end, however, all fraud comes down to a few common modus operandi. It usually involves one or all of the following:

- Getting the targets themselves to reveal their details
- Persuading the victim to download a remote access/ screen-sharing app to